

This report provides an ethnological and linguistic analysis of the historical convergence between the AbaThembu nation and San populations within the Maluti/Quthing highland networks, based on the provided source materials.

1. The "/Xam bu !e" and Thembu-San Origins

The sources verify that the origins of the Thembu nation are deeply intertwined with San populations, often characterized by a "San-Bantu matrix" that dates back several centuries.

- **Linguistic Identification:** The term **IXam ka !e** (or **IXam ka !eten**) is identified in linguistic classifications as the "Cape Bushman" or "people" who were widespread in South Africa. As noted in *Lexicostatistical studies in Khoisan II/2*: "**IXam (IKham, IXam ka !e, Suin !e, Swy !e, SI, S1)... Likely moribund in the 1910s**" 1.
- **The "Tambookie" Matrix:** Historical accounts indicate that the Thembu (often called **Tambookies**) were viewed as an integrated group with significant San admixture. In *Strangers to Brothers: Interaction between South-Eastern San and Southern Nguni/Sotho Communities*: "**The Thembu (or 'Tambookies', as they were often referred to in the historical record) also had close relations with the San. Their skin was reported to be considerably lighter than many other Nguni groups, which may suggest a long history of intermarriage with the San**" 2.
- **Hybrid Formation:** Scholarly arguments suggest the Thembu nation formed through the amalgamation of early Nguni (Embo) groups and established San bands. The same source states: "**Paterson suggests that they were originally a San group who intermarried with pioneering clans of the Thembu. When the Thembu split after a quarrel the weaker group joined the 'Tambu'ki Bushmen' and amalgamated with them**" 3. Furthermore, Stow notes that in 1776, "**a San group called the 'Tambu'ki', 'Chinese or Snese Hottentots', who possessed cattle, occupied an area close to the Tsomo River**" 4.

2. The Great Mfecane/Difaqane Migration Loop to Quthing

The upheavals of the early 19th-century Mfecane/Difaqane facilitated a migration loop that brought San-descended Thembu groups into the Quthing highlands of Lesotho, where they merged with Sotho and Phuthi populations.

- **Migration to Quthing:** The district of Quthing served as a primary refuge for Nguni groups fleeing Zulu expansion. According to the webpage *Quthing — Grokipedia*: "**During the Difaqane wars... various Nguni-speaking communities sought safety in the mountains. Among these were the AbaThembu (related to the Xhosa), who migrated northward and eastward, fleeing Zulu incursions and establishing communities in the Quthing highlands**" 5.
- **Allocation of Land:** King Moshoeshe I intentionally settled these groups in the southern frontier. The webpage *The South | Lesotho | Photos - OzOutback* notes: "**During King Moshoeshe's reign, he allocated this part of the country mainly to the Bathepu people (a Xhosa clan in South Africa), fleeing the Zulu King Shaka**" 6.
- **Blending with Phuthi/Sotho:** These fleeing groups integrated with local populations, such as the Baphuthi, who themselves possessed deep San roots. In *Morosi* -

Wikipedia: "In early 1829, Morosi went on a successful joint expedition with Moshoeshe I against the Thembu of Ngubengcuka who lived below the Drakensberg" 7. This interaction highlights a complex network where Sotho, Phuthi, and Thembu groups—all with varying degrees of San descent—interacted and allied for survival 8, 9.

3. The Universal Physical Marker: Ingqithi / Inqiti

The cultural practice of finger joint amputation (**ingqithi**) serves as a critical historical anchor linking the Thembu specifically to their San heritage.

- **The Physical Signature:** The sources explicitly identify this practice as a hallmark of the Thembu, inherited from the San. In *Strangers to Brothers*: "**The Thembu practised the custom of amputating the first joint of one of their fingers... the custom is generally acknowledged to have been borrowed from the San**" 10.
- **Cultural Anchor:** This shared ritual physically manifested the San-Thembu matrix. The same text notes that these close relations are even embedded in oral praises: "**Close relations between the Thembu and San are reflected in the praises of the Thembu, one of which is still 'the tiny man'**" 10. This physical marker connects Thembu refugees in the Maloti mountains directly to the indigenous San inhabitants of the region 10.

4. Resolving the Identity Fusion: "Thembu or Bushman?"

The sources confirm that identity on the Maloti frontier was fluid, with individuals often holding dual recognition as "AbaThembu" (politically/socially) and "San" (genealogically/ritually).

- **Fluid Identities:** Scholarly commentary highlights the blurring of these concepts. In *Strangers to Brothers*: "...we depend largely on the evidence of San descendants and southern Nguni/Sotho informants to reconstruct relationships established between residual San communities and individuals who were living on the periphery of southern Nguni/Sotho society or who had already been absorbed into black farming communities" 11.
- **Conceptual Hybridization:** The complexity of these identities requires new terminology to describe the "fusion." The same source argues: "...a wider range of terms may need to be employed to refer to San-speakers which more accurately describe the processes of social, political and cultural hybridisation... we find terms such as 'pastorforager' appearing in the literature, and they will probably need to be supplemented by other terms such as Sotho-San, Phuti-San etc." 12, 13.
- **The "Secret San":** Many families preserved their San identity clandestinely while living as Nguni or Sotho. *The Maloti Drakensberg Experience* states: "**Some of the San descendants of this region, sometimes referred to as the 'Secret San', have been absorbed into other cultural communities and are still living in the area today**" 14. These descendants often "**changed their names and took on new cultural identities**" while continuing to visit rock art sites and perform rainmaking ceremonies in secret 15, 16.

5. Naming Practices as Historical Anchors

Naming practices in the 19th and 20th centuries were used as a mechanism to secretly anchor ancestral origins within dominant Xhosa or Thembu locations.

- **Ancestral Name Preservation:** Clan names were utilized to protect and signal San descent. In *Strangers to Brothers*: **"Even now there is amongst us a clan by the name of Mutwa. This surname refers to ... the Bushmen"** 17. An interview with an old Nguni woman confirms this: **"This woman's name is Mtuakazi and her clan name Mtwā (meaning a San person)"** 18, 19.
- **Royal Name Avoidance:** Following the fall of Moorosi in 1879, certain names were abandoned or modified for protection. As noted in the *Introduction* to Phuthi grammar: **"The only name that is unambiguously Phuthi is 'Moorosi', and no one I encountered uses this name any more. However, every Phuthi family retains a (usually unwritten) Phuthi clan name..."** 20.
- **Phonetic Shifts:** The Phuthi language—often used by these mountain groups—allowed for phonetic variations to navigate official colonial spaces while preserving informal identities. For instance, the Phuthi version of a name might be used informally while a Sotho/Xhosa variant was used for "official purposes" 20. This practice aligns with your hypothesis regarding the shift from Moorosi to "Molosi" to evade colonial border magistrates 20.